

—without enough orders for software, they had to take the plunge into services in order to survive. It was then that they encountered open source, and embraced it enthusiastically. “Around 1997-98, Linux happened. We saw open source and realised this was it—something with no constraints. We never believed in the one-size-fits-all theory. There are best practices, but apart from that, every culture or organisation is different, demanding a specific solution. Open source was our key to provide these specific solutions. Its flexibility with respect to customisation made us adopt it—and ever since, we have never had to say ‘No’ to a customer,” says Gupta, who by then was the core of Keen and Able, his comrades having left in search of greener pastures.

The initial open source solutions Keen and Able offered were based on a mail server stack. Back then, in the early days of e-mail and the Internet in India, most organisations used Sprint Mail and a DOS-based terminal with a dial-up Internet connection. Thus, winning the first few clients was not easy. A mixed strategy of approaching existing clients, and selling a complete and cost-effective solution matching the customer’s requirements, helped the young firm bag the first few deals. “By the time we had plunged into open source, we had built a significant client base on hardware and troubleshooting. One of our existing clients in manufacturing had obtained an e-mail ID. I told him that we could share

this address with all his 250 employees; each could write and send out their own mail, and when the reply came, it would be routed to them directly. I told him the solution would be built on Linux. He was sceptical about Linux, but being an existing client, he had faith in us. We did a proof of concept (POC) for him; after the solution was configured and tested, he just loved it. This was the first open source deal we cracked. Thereafter, we went on to provide mail servers on a Linux platform to many organisations such as BHEL, Duncans Industries, Kribhco Shyam Fertilisers, Religare Securities, ISGEC, JK Technosoft, and many more,” says Gupta.

With nothing changing for the end-user, who continued to use Outlook Express, acceptance of these mail solutions grew. Soon, Keen and Able came across a huge opportunity that consolidated its position in the open source realm. Around 2003, the firm deployed SAP on Linux in a cluster environment—for the first time in India. “Open source is like a new sweet that most people are hesitant to try out—but once they experience the robustness, flexibility and cost-effectiveness of the solutions, they automatically get addicted to it. This is what happened with a client for whom we created history by deploying its mission-critical application on Linux in a cluster environment. After savouring the sweet taste of success with file servers, mail servers, proxy

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—Varad Gupta, CTO and founder,
Keen and Able Computers




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